

blue lines, flags flying, moving toward them. Union artillery fired a barrage so deafening that individual guns could not be distinguished. Hood's men repulsed the assaults on their front; but that was only a diversion. The Federals turning their left flank were the real striking force. They swarmed over fields and stone walls taking one Rebel position after another, capturing 16 guns and a thousand prisoners before winter darkness halted their momentum. That night Hood withdrew to another set of bluffs, where his weary soldiers cut trees and entrenched in the dark. Dawn revealed an imposing new line of Confederate works curving over a steep 3-mile (4.8-km) front.

Union surge

Gray clouds and cold rain had arrived by the time Thomas's attack again got underway. On the Confederate right, the Federals struggling upward were slaughtered in terrible profusion. But to his left, Hood's line had been sited too far up the slope; the defenders could not train their guns on the enemy until it was too late. Hood's left began giving way, and when the Union cavalry got into its rear, it broke. Panic spread like wildfire. Down the line exultant Federals seized guns, ammunition, flags, and thousands of dazed Confederates. Entire divisions melted away, soldiers fleeing to the rear ignoring their officers' cries to rally. It was as decisive a victory as any in the war. The Army of Tennessee, once among the proudest in the Confederacy, had reached the limit of its endurance. Its men fled down the Franklin Pike in the rain. Later that night, Hood was observed "much agitated and affected, pulling his hair with his one hand and crying like his heart would break."